

MY457: Seminar 5 Guiding Questions

2026-03-30

Paper:

Paper: Zhang, R., 2026. Higher education expansion and the rural–urban gap in secondary schooling and labor outcomes: Evidence from China’s 1999 reform. *Journal of Development Economics*.

Guiding Questions:

1. General

- What is the primary causal question of interest?
- Conceptually, what is the causal variable, and what is the primary outcome?
- Explain the causal inference problem. Why can the authors not just collect data on available university places/options, their outcomes of interest, and run bivariate regressions?

2. Data structure and research design

- Explain the data structure. What is the unit of analysis and what are the observations?
- What are the two dimensions of comparison?
- Describe the treatment grouping variable (G_i in lecture 10), the pre-post variable (T), and the actual treatment variables (Z_{it}).
- At what level is treatment assigned?

3. Assumptions

- What are the key assumptions underpinning the design? How does the author assess the credibility of their design? Is this convincing? Can you think of any other tests that might be useful?
- Do you have any concerns about the design?

4. Interpretation

- What type of difference-in-differences design is this?
- What is the estimand targeted by this design? Is that a useful quantity?